Q+A

REVIVING TRADITION

***Radhikaraje Gaekwad** blends heritage and inclusivity through the Heritage Garba and Urja crafts festival*

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH



Q. The Lukshmi Vilas Palace, Vadodara, hosted the garba recently. What has been your guiding light in hosting what has come to be one of the most anticipated garbas in the garba capital of Gujarat?

The Heritage Garba is our flagship fund-raising event and spreads awareness about the Shri Maharani Chimnabai Stree Udyogalaya (MCSU). Traditionally, there is no record of the royal family participating in the garba, being a Maratha family, perhaps. But I am a Gujarati and a full garba fanatic. My husband and I decided to give our patronage and start a new tradition. In the third year, in 2024, it was my husband's idea to move the Heritage Garba to the Palace grounds.

Q. MCSU has taken up the cause of artisans through various activities, one of them being the two-day Urja craft festival, now held on the Palace grounds. How was the festival conceived and how has it evolved?

Urja started in 2020 during the pandemic when artisans were frantic after their orders were cancelled. I was feeling helpless for them, so I started circulating PDFs of their products in my networks and on social media. Then I realised we could provide them a stage and sensitise people. Urja started with 30 exhibitors—20 artisans and around 10 design studios—to help them connect with each other and with the end-consumer.

Q. How is Urja curated? What is your philosophy in putting together the event?

I curate Urja as a continuous process round the year through my travels and the multiple channels through which I am connected in the crafts network and to artisans. I keep an eye out for diversity, region and product diversity. The fifth edition moved to the Palace as we required more space.

*—with **Jumana Shah***